

CAESAR, JULIUS



JULIUS CAESAR WAS A BRILLIANT general and ruler of the Roman world. He is one of the most famous, and controversial, figures in history. He transformed the Roman world, expanding Rome's territory into Gaul and suppressing many revolts. He was a fine administrator, reforming the Roman calendar and Roman law and bringing strong government to the republic. Caesar was also a great writer and orator. But he could be unscrupulous in pursuit of his own interests, and made many enemies during his career.

Triumvirate

In the years leading up to 60 BC, rival politicians competed to gain power. Order was restored when Caesar, the financier Marcus Crassus, and the army commander Pompey set up a three-man committee, or triumvirate, to rule Rome. In 59 BC, the triumvirate allowed Caesar to be elected consul, one of the two magistrates who held supreme power. As consul, Caesar strengthened and reformed the government.



Pompey

Gnaeus Pompeius Magnus (106–48 BC), known in English as Pompey, was a Roman general who conquered Palestine and Syria, and did much to get rid of opposition to Roman rule in Spain and Sicily. Although he was a member of the triumvirate and he married Caesar's daughter, he was always Caesar's rival.

Pompey the Great



Early life

Caesar was born in Rome in about 100 BC. A member of a rich family, he had a successful military and political career, rising through various offices to become Pontifex Maximus, or high priest, in 64 BC. In 61 BC he became Governor of Further Spain, one of the most important jobs in the Roman republic.

Galic wars

From 58–50 BC, Caesar waged a series of wars which led to the incorporation of Gaul (modern France and Belgium) into the Roman republic. Caesar displayed great military ability in the Gallic Wars, and was ruthless with any tribes who tried to resist conquest.

Caesar recorded his achievements in his famous memoirs of the campaign.



Roman legionary's helmet

Civil war

After the death of Crassus in 53 BC, rivalry between Caesar and Pompey reached new heights. Pompey became sole consul in 52 BC and, with the support of the Roman senate (parliament), declared Caesar an enemy of the people. In 49 BC, Caesar crossed the Rubicon, the river dividing Italy from Gaul, and marched on Rome in triumph. In 48 BC he defeated Pompey. By 45 BC, Caesar had removed all opposition, becoming master of the Roman world.



Caesar crosses the Rubicon.



Roman catapult bolts



Roman cavalry spur

Pharsalus

Caesar showed his military skills when, in 48 BC, he defeated the much larger army of Pompey near the Greek town of Pharsalus. Caesar's strategic sense and better location enabled his small force to overwhelm Pompey's army, which was routed. Pompey himself fled to Egypt, where he died.

Battle of Pharsalus

Cleopatra

Caesar followed Pompey to Egypt and remained in the country after Pompey's death. He befriended and lived with Cleopatra, queen of Egypt, and helped establish her firmly on the throne. When Caesar returned to Rome in 47 BC, Cleopatra came with him. After Caesar's death, the Egyptian queen had twin sons with the Roman soldier and politician Mark Antony (c.82–30 BC).



Antony and Cleopatra

Dictator

In 45 BC, Caesar was appointed dictator for life. He reformed the living conditions of the Roman people by passing new agricultural laws and improving housing. He also made the republic more secure from its enemies.

Assassination

Despite his reforms, Caesar's dictatorial rule made him enemies in Rome. On 15 March 44 BC – the Ides of March – Caesar was stabbed to death in the senate house by rival senators, including Cassius and Brutus. But his work lived on in his great-nephew and adopted son, Octavian, who became emperor.

Assassination of Caesar



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JULIUS CAESAR

c.100 BC Born in Rome.

80 BC First military service in Turkey.

60 BC Forms triumvirate with Crassus and Pompey.

59 BC Elected consul.

58–50 BC Conquers Gaul.

50 BC Roman senate declares him an enemy of the people.

49 BC Starts civil war against Pompey.

48 BC Defeats Pompey and follows him to Egypt.

44 BC Assassinated in the senate in Rome by rival senators.